



◀ Potential Buddhas

Two women stand by a tree in a fan-shaped album of Hoke-kyo Sutra—teachings of the Mahayana branch of Buddhism. The sutra reveals that women have the potential to become Buddhas.

▼ Court chronicles

Shikibu keenly observed the sexual intrigue, social plots, and marital politics that surrounded her in the imperial court in *The Tale of Genji*. A scene from the enduringly popular novel is illustrated in this Yamato-style painting.

of *Genji*. Composed in the 11th century by Murasaki Shikibu, it is widely considered the world's first novel and a masterpiece of world literature. Sei Shōnagon, a contemporary of Shikibu, also vividly captured Heian court life in *The Pillow Book* (c. 1002). In brilliant and original prose, she makes witty, insightful observations of Japan's late 10th-century elite. Fujiwara Michitsuna's *The Mayfly Diary* (c. 974) is a haunting record of the author's unhappy marriage to a Fujiwara courtier.

Despite women's prominence in Heian culture, their role in politics was limited. Earlier in Japanese history, men and women had reigned in equal numbers, but by the start of the Heian era, female sovereigns yielded less power in government. However, they remained influential as mothers of emperors, and were formally designated as empress mother or empress dowager (*kōtaigō*).

